

THE

ARCANE AETHER

A rules-light fantasy game about rewriting reality

VERSION 4.6 · INITIAL FULL-BOOK DRAFT

Contents

- The Arcane Aether 1
 - Origin of magic relics 1
 - What makes it different 1
- Core Rules 2
 - The dice 2
 - Luck 2
 - Magical casting 2
 - Exposure and Mutation 3
 - Magic items 3
 - Inventory and conditions 4
 - Movement 4
 - Combat 4
 - Health, Scars, and recovery 5
 - Death and dying 5
- Character Creation 6
 - Step 1: Basic details 6
 - Step 2: Choose an Archetype 6
 - Step 3: Key goals 6
 - Step 4: Starting mutation 7
- Archetypes 8
 - Hunter 8
 - Thief 8
 - Performer 8
 - Monk 9
 - Fighter 9
 - Witch 9
- Game Master Guide 10
 - Monsters 10
- Bestiary 11
- Reference Tables 12
 - Mutation Table 12
 - Wild Magic 12
 - Spell Tag Sparks 13
 - Key Ideas 13
 - Key Terms 13

The Arcane Aether

The Arcane Aether is a rules-light fantasy game about ordinary people who discover that reality can be rewritten.

I am trying to explore two ideas with these rules:

- Can magic stay open-ended and weird while still being fun at the table?
- Can a simple system let characters progress during play, as a direct result of the choices made in a session?

It is inspired by *Powered by the Apocalypse*, *Shadowdark*, *Blades in the Dark*, *Cairn*, and other games where characters take shape through play.

I am not very concerned with encounter balance, and the game does not offer many guardrails. I want something quick to learn and quick to get into play, with room for silly, out-of-the-box ideas. I also like the thought that you can borrow magic from any other game and see what it does here.

As a GM, I like to play to find out and leave room for freeform play. I want simple monster creation and fast, fluid fights when the players decide to fight.

Origin of magic relics

Why are there so many magic items? Why do the people capable of making them keep leaving them in tombs, shops, and holes in the ground?

In this game, Arcanists make magic items because they need somewhere to put their Exposure before it changes them. They pour it into objects, use those objects for a while, and eventually have to leave some of them behind. Every relic came from someone with a problem. That was the idea I wanted to explore, and the rest of the game grew around it.

What makes it different

There is no spell list. A player says what they want their character's magic to do and prices its reach, force, and duration. The GM confirms or adjusts the cost, then the player decides if the effect is worth the Exposure. You do not need to predict every possible spell. You just need to understand what the player is asking for and make the Exposure cost clear.

Advance by trying in play

I want character progression to happen while everyone is playing, not as a separate downtime step or paperwork after the game. Characters gain Luck when things go badly and when they complete their goals.

Players can spend that Luck to improve their character's stats, help one another, or play out a flashback scene that changes the present scene. Players learn to be better at

casting by attempting to cast, but at the cost of slowly collecting mutations that fill up their limited inventory. It should be clear that all obstacles in this game are solvable through magic and teamwork.

Monsters should be easy to run

A monster needs four numbers and answers to two questions: what does it want, and what is its weakness? Monster tiers are numbered 1 to 6. When I do not want to decide how dangerous something should be, I let the dice decide.

I do not think every encounter needs to be balanced. Tell the players what their characters can see, let them decide what risks to take, and follow the consequences. The monster's Desire also leaves room for a bargain when another attack roll would be less interesting.

Strange ideas are allowed to work

Not everything needs a roll. Let the silly ideas move the story. Maybe a character knows how to speak Orc because they once spent a summer in an Orc camp pretending to be a baby Orc's doll, that sounds good to me.

Core Rules

The Arcane Aether is a rules-light game about ordinary people who can reshape reality and must live with the cost.

The dice

Say what your character intends to do. **Roll 2d6 plus the fitting stat.** Casting uses one relevant Spell Tag instead. Roll when the outcome is uncertain and failure would change the situation. Otherwise, let it happen or tell the player what it costs in time or resources.

Total	Result
6 or less	Failure. It goes wrong. Resolve the failure, then gain 1 Luck.
7 to 9	Partial success. Your character does it, but there is a complication.
10 or greater	Full success. Your character achieves what they intended.
Double 1s	Tragic failure.
Double 6s	Critical success.

Check doubles on the two dice that determine the result.

Double 1s or double 6s replace the normal result.

When no more specific doubles rule applies, the GM adds a severe or lasting consequence to a Tragic failure. On a Critical success, your character achieves what they intended and gains an extra benefit chosen by the GM.

A complication should move events forward. Your character might lose something, end up in danger, attract attention, or get hurt. A partial success still accomplishes what you rolled for.

Luck

Each character can hold up to **10 Luck**.

Gain **1 Luck** after you accept and resolve a failed roll. Gain **2 Luck** when your character achieves a Key Goal and you cross it off their list.

You may give your Luck to another player whenever you like.

Spending Luck

Cost	Buy
1	Add one die to your roll and keep the highest two.
1	Assist another character.
2	Play a flashback that can affect the present.
5	Advance your character.

Add a die

Spend 1 Luck before resolving a roll. Roll **3d6 and keep the highest two**. Only the kept dice count for double 1s or double 6s.

Assist another character

Spend 1 Luck and explain how your character helps. The active player adds 1d6 to their roll and keeps the highest two dice.

If the roll fails, only the active player gains 1 Luck. Everyone who assisted shares the consequences of a failure or partial success.

Flashbacks

Spend 2 Luck to play a short scene from your character's past that affects the present. Maybe they bribed the kitchen servant to leave the back door unlocked.

Play the scene and roll if its outcome is uncertain. Then return to the present with the result. Costs and consequences apply normally. In a turn, the flashback counts as your character's action.

Advancement

Spend 5 Luck to choose one:

- Increase a stat by 1, to a maximum of +3.
- Increase a Spell Tag by 1, to a maximum of +3.
- Increase maximum Health by 1.
- Gain an Archetype Perk.

Magical casting

Your character can command the patterns of Aether and reshape reality through thought and imagination.

1. Describe the effect: its reach or size, what it does, and how long it lasts.
2. Add its Exposure cost using the casting dials.
3. The GM confirms the cost or adjusts it for anything unusual.
4. Accept the final cost or reduce the effect, then roll 2d6 plus one relevant Spell Tag.

Casting follows the normal roll results, with these additional effects:

- **Failure:** The cast fails and costs no Exposure. Resolve the failure, then gain 1 Luck.
- **Partial success:** The cast works. Mark the agreed Exposure and suffer a complication.
- **Full success:** The cast works. Mark the agreed Exposure and add a beneficial flourish beyond the intended effect.
- **Double 1s:** The cast fails and costs no Exposure. Roll d66 on the Wild Magic table.
- **Double 6s:** The cast works. Mark the agreed Exposure, then gain a new Spell Tag related to the cast or increase the Tag used by 1, to a maximum of +3.

A beneficial flourish cannot add damage, reach, size, or duration that was not included in the Exposure cost.

Spell Tags

Spell Tags represent what your character has learned through casting. Fire, invisibility, healing, ice, mind reading, floating, talking to animals, light, pain, and poison are all possible Tags.

Choose one relevant Spell Tag for each cast and add its rating to the roll. Tags do not stack, run out, reduce Exposure, or limit what your character may attempt.

Without a relevant Tag, roll 2d6 with no bonus.

Casting never uses a Stat. Only one relevant Spell Tag can add to the roll.

When your character gains a Mutation through casting or you roll double 6s on a cast, gain a new +1 Tag related to the cast or increase the Tag used by 1, to a maximum of +3. If both happen on the same cast, gain this benefit only once. The Spell Tags table is a prompt sheet, not a spell list.

Casting limits

Mutations allow your character's body to withstand more Exposure. Their safe limit for one cast is:

3 plus their number of Mutations.

You may have your character cast above this limit. On a success, first mark the full Exposure and resolve any resulting Mutations. Then mark 1 Fatigue for each point of Exposure above the limit.

A spell's Exposure cost

Exposure = Reach or Size + Force and Effect + Duration.

Every cast costs at least **1 Exposure**. A harmless, instant effect at touching range, such as creating a spark of flame, costs 1.

Reach or Size	Add
Your character, or one creature or object they touch	1
A medium room, a handful of people, or a wagon-sized object	2
Across a field, a building, a street, or a field of targets	3
Barely in sight or beyond it	4

Use the highest Reach or Size cost. Do not add reach and size together. For a transformation, price the larger form.

Force and Effect	Add
A change without forceful impact, such as a spark, transformation, invisibility, or gentle floating	0
A firm shove, deal 1 damage, or restore 1 Health	1
A hard throw, deal 2 damage, or restore 2 Health	2
A crushing impact, deal 3 damage, restore 3 Health, or heal one Scar	3

Duration	Add
Instant, or until the end of the current scene	0
A few hours, up to a day	1
More than a day, up to a month	2
More than a month, up to a year	3
Years, but less than a lifetime	4
A lifetime or forever	5

Magical damage is the amount bought with Exposure. It is not doubled or tripled by the casting result.

Magical damage and healing use the same Force and Effect costs. One tears the body down. The other puts it back together.

For scrying, mind reading, and other information magic, Reach is how far away the subject is and Duration is how long the character observes. If the spell only gathers information, its Force and Effect is 0. Discovery, misleading visions, or the subject sensing the intrusion may still be consequences when they fit.

Casting effects end when their paid Duration expires. A portal closes, a transformed person returns to their previous form, invisibility ends, and a flying boat comes back down.

Damage and healing normally happen instantly and remain afterward. A healing zone includes its Reach or Size, the Health it restores, and its Duration. Each character can benefit from the zone once per cast.

Magic may start a fire, but the fire continues only while it has fuel.

Exposure and Mutation

Exposure is a little like radiation poisoning. It collects as your character uses the Arcane Aether, letting them reshape the world while it reshapes them.

Whenever the character reaches **10 Exposure**, they undergo a Mutation. Roll on the Mutation table. The Mutation permanently occupies an inventory slot. Subtract 10 Exposure and keep any excess.

If a cast also causes Fatigue, resolve its Exposure and any resulting Mutations before marking the Fatigue.

Magic items

An Arcanist can move Exposure out of their body and into an object, creating a magical relic.

A relic:

- Takes one inventory slot.
- Holds up to **6 Exposure**.
- Takes an undisturbed hour to create or refill.
- Has one magical function chosen when it is created.
- Can be created or refilled once per Arcanist per in-game day.

During that hour, choose how much Exposure to transfer, up to the relic's capacity. Subtract it from the character's current Exposure and record it in the relic.

Anyone who can operate the relic can activate it. Choose the reach or size, force and effect, and duration within the relic's function. Price the activation using the normal casting dials and subtract that cost from the relic's stored Exposure. No casting roll is made, and the user gains no Exposure.

The relic cannot produce an activation that costs more Exposure than it currently holds. At zero Exposure, it is an ordinary object until an Arcanist refills it.

An Arcanist may instead create an inert vessel, such as a soul jar, that stores Exposure but has no magical function. It follows all the other relic rules.

Relics can be traded or sold like other valuable objects.

Inventory and conditions

Your character has **12 inventory slots**. Gear fills from the top down. Conditions fill from the bottom up, taking the lowest available slot.

An item usually takes one slot. Small things of the same kind bundle together, such as a handful of arrows, spikes, or three rations. Worn armor does not take a slot.

Mutations, Scars, and Fatigue are conditions. If one takes a slot holding an item, that item is dropped.

When conditions claim all twelve slots, the character is lost. The final condition determines what happens in Death and dying.

Movement

A move shifts your character one zone toward or away from something. Skip their action to take a second move.

Zone	Meaning
Close	Melee. Close enough to touch.
Near	Across the room. One move to Close.
Far	Two moves from Close. Bowshot.

Walls, locked doors, crowds, and deep holes still matter.

Combat

Characters act first, then enemies. The players roll 1d6. The highest roll goes first, then play moves clockwise around the table. If the characters are surprised, the attackers act first.

Your character's turn

Your character can take **one move and one action** in either order. They can attack, cast, catch their breath, use something, assist someone, or try something else.

Roll **2d6 plus Strength** for hand-to-hand combat or **2d6 plus Dexterity** for a ranged attack. Your character must be able to reach the target with what they are using.

Result	Effect
Failure	The attack fails and the situation gets worse.
Partial success	Deal the weapon's damage and suffer a complication.
Full success	Deal double the weapon's damage.
Double 6s	Deal triple damage and ignore Armor.
Double 1s	The attack fails. The character takes 1 damage or their weapon breaks, whichever fits.

On a failure or partial success, an enemy may hurt your character, push them back, damage their gear, or create another fitting complication. The enemy still takes its regular turn.

Damage and Armor

Weapons deal damage based on their size and weight:

- Small or concealable: **1 damage**.
- Normal: **2 damage**.
- Heavy or two-handed: **3 damage**.

Apply damage added by a Perk before doubling or tripling the attack.

Armor reduces incoming damage. Worn armor and shields stack to a maximum of **3 Armor**, although Mythic creatures may have more.

When your character takes damage, subtract their Armor. If the damage exceeds the Armor, apply the remaining damage and the Armor breaks. If the damage does not exceed the Armor, apply no damage and leave the Armor intact.

A critical success ignores Armor without breaking it. Broken Armor must be repaired by someone with the necessary skills. Pay them or owe them a favor.

When enemies attack

Use the enemy's Threat from Monsters. The GM rolls **2d6 plus Threat**.

Total	Result
6 or less	The attack misses.
7 to 9	Deal the enemy's listed damage.
10 or greater	Deal the enemy's listed damage and cause a complication.
Double 6s	Deal triple damage and ignore Armor.
Double 1s	The attack fails and the enemy suffers a mishap.

A crowd attacking one target rolls once, using its highest Threat and best single damage. Its numbers can still block exits, surround a character, or create other complications.

Health, Scars, and recovery

Subtract damage from your character's current Health. Their Archetype sets the maximum. Health cannot fall below zero.

When a hit brings the character to zero Health, mark one Scar. Each damaging hit taken at zero Health causes another Scar. A single hit causes only one Scar, regardless of excess damage.

Each Scar occupies an inventory slot until removed.

Restoring Health does not remove Scars.

Healing

- **A couple of quiet hours:** Roll 2d6 and restore that much Health if the character has no Fatigue.
- **A full night's rest:** Remove one Fatigue. If none remains afterward, restore all Health.

To catch their breath, spend the character's action and roll **2d6 plus Willpower**. They cannot do this while Fatigued.

Total	Result
6 or less	Restore no Health. The situation gets worse. After resolving the failure, gain 1 Luck.
7 to 9	Restore 1 Health.
10 or greater	Restore 2 Health.
Double 1s	Restore no Health and resolve a Tragic failure.
Double 6s	Restore 3 Health. On the character's next turn, roll 3d6 and keep the highest two for their first roll.

Health cannot exceed the character's maximum. Fatigue prevents all Health recovery, including magical healing. Removing a Scar requires magic or about a week of care from a healer. Removing it frees its inventory slot.

Death and dying

The condition that claims your character's final inventory slot determines their fate.

Final condition	Ending
Mutation	The character becomes a Demon. The Aether has changed them beyond themselves.
Scar	The character's body dies. Their spirit passes on, or lingers because of unfinished business.
Fatigue	The character is taken by the Aether. They have nothing left to hold it back.

The character becomes part of the world's lore, and the player makes someone new. A lingering spirit may still matter, but the character's playable life is over.

Character Creation

Make someone who had a life before they became an Arcanist. Four steps are enough to begin. The rest can come out during play.

Step 1: Basic details

Give your character a name and a few details: their age, appearance, voice, and where they are from. A line is plenty.

Then choose a Life Type and record both of its traits. Humans, elves, goblins, cat people, karate turtles, and stranger things all have a place in this world.

Life types

Human

- **Resilient:** Once a day, ignore one Fatigue as it would be marked.
- **I Know a Guy:** Once per session, declare that your character knows someone useful in the current location. Tell the table how they know each other.

Elf

- **Foresight:** Play one free flashback per session.
- **Old Grudge:** When old knowledge or an old event matters, your character remembers because they were there.

Goblin

- **Overlooked:** Add +1 when your character hides, squeezes, scurries, or goes unnoticed.
- **Goblin Friends:** If a goblin is involved, your character knows them. Tell the table how.

Beastfolk

Choose the animal that shapes your character.

- **Natural Weapons:** Their unarmed attacks deal 2 damage.
- **Keen Senses:** Add +1 when they use one heightened sense appropriate to that animal.

Otherfolk

Otherfolk includes people commonly thought of as monsters, such as crab people, intelligent oozes, lizard folk, vampires, or skeletons.

Choose one body advantage that fits what your character is. Describe what it lets them do.

Examples:

- A shell or thick hide gives 1 Armor.
- A lizard person may use their tail as a weapon.
- A vampire may turn into a bat.
- A skeleton may detach and reattach their limbs.

Step 2: Choose an Archetype

Your character's Archetype represents the life they led before becoming an Arcanist.

Choose one. Take its starting gear, maximum Health, and one Perk. Use its suggested Stats, or arrange **+2, +1, 0, and -1** across the four Stats yourself.

Stat	What it covers
Strength	Muscle, force, fighting hand to hand
Dexterity	Speed, stealth, precision, ranged attacks
Willpower	Endurance and resolve
Charm	Persuasion and presence

Set your character's current Health equal to their maximum Health.

Archetype	Old life	Health
Hunter	Tracked Arcanists for coin, then woke up as one.	7
Thief	Lived by wit, speed, and other people's things.	6
Performer	Lived by fast talk and knowing everyone worth knowing.	6
Monk	Studied the ancient arts and honed their body into a weapon.	7
Fighter	Someone paid them to stand in the way, and they never learned to stop.	8
Witch	Had a place in an order once, then something answered.	5

If none fit, work with the GM to create an old life. Use the same Stat array and choose starting gear, maximum Health, and one Perk based on the existing Archetypes.

Pack the gear

Your character has **12 inventory slots**. Put their Archetype gear into the slots from the top down. Worn Armor does not take a slot.

Small things of the same kind bundle together. Three rations, a handful of arrows, or several iron spikes each take one slot.

Step 3: Key goals

Write up to four Key Goals your character wants to achieve. They should matter enough to make the character go out into the world and do something about them.

They can be serious or ridiculous:

- Get revenge on the person who killed their mother.
- Burn down the silly hat shop.
- Find out what happened to their sister.
- Buy back the family house.

Choose goals with a clear end. When your character achieves one, cross it off and gain **2 Luck**.

Share the goals with the other players. Their characters might share one, want to help, or have a very good reason to keep that hat shop standing.

Step 4: Starting mutation

Decide whether the Aether has already changed your character.

I Start Unchanged

- Begin with no Mutations and no Spell Tags.
- Their safe casting limit is 3 Exposure.
- Begin with 0 current Exposure, 0 Luck, no Scars, and no Fatigue.

I Start Marked

- Roll on the Mutation table and record the result in inventory slot 12.
- Choose one +1 Spell Tag related to the Mutation or the event that made the character an Arcanist.
- Their safe casting limit is 4 Exposure.
- Begin with 0 current Exposure, 0 Luck, no Scars, and no Fatigue.

Starting Marked gives the character more control over magic, but the Aether has already taken one of their twelve slots.

Archetypes

Hunter

Tracked Arcanists for coin, then woke up as one.

Strength	Dexterity	Willpower	Charm
+2	0	+1	-1
Starting Health			
7			

Starting Gear

Short sword, 2 damage

Crossbow, 2 damage

Manacles

Iron spikes

Big hammer, 1 damage

Rations x3

Chainmail, Armor 1

d6	Perk
1	Roll with advantage when following tracks.
2	Add Dexterity to damage with a bow or crossbow.
3	Roll with advantage when telling if someone is lying.
4	Your character can travel without leaving a trail.
5	Your character is an expert at barbecuing meat.
6	Increase one Stat by 1, to a maximum of +3.

Performer

Lived by fast talk and knowing everyone worth knowing.

Strength	Dexterity	Willpower	Charm
-1	+1	0	+2
Starting Health			
6			

Starting Gear

Short sword, 2 damage

Disguise kit

A ring of stolen keys

Padded coat, Armor 1

Torch

Rations x3

d6	Perk
1	Once a day, declare that your character knows someone who can help.
2	Once a day, give advantage to any roll.
3	Strangers assume your character belongs here until given a reason to doubt it.
4	Once a session, name someone who owes your character a favor. They do.
5	Once a day, your character knows the perfect song for this moment.
6	Increase one Stat by 1, to a maximum of +3.

Thief

Lived by wit, speed, and other people's things.

Strength	Dexterity	Willpower	Charm
-1	+2	+1	0
Starting Health			
6			

Starting Gear

Double daggers, 2 damage

Leather Armor, Armor 1

Lockpick kit

Grappling hook

60 feet of rope

Smoke pellets that hide the character from sight

Rations x3

d6	Perk
1	Once a day, your character can slip by without being noticed.
2	Deal +1 damage to something that has not seen your character.
3	Roll with advantage when pickpocketing.
4	Once a day, your character has the perfect underworld contact.
5	Roll with advantage when picking locks and safes.
6	Increase one Stat by 1, to a maximum of +3.

Monk

Studied the ancient arts and honed their body into a weapon.

Strength	Dexterity	Willpower	Charm
+1	+2	0	-1
Starting Health			
7			

Starting Gear

Walking staff, 2 damage

Bandages and salves, 3 uses, restore 1d6 Health

60 feet of knotted rope

Throwing stars x4

Torch

Rations x3

d6	Perk
1	Add Strength to damage with unarmed strikes.
2	Gain +1 Armor while your character can move freely.
3	Your character can leap 20 feet and perch on anything that will hold a toe.
4	Your character can enchant creatures and people with music.
5	No fall hurts your character if they can see it coming.
6	Increase one Stat by 1, to a maximum of +3.

Fighter

Someone paid your character to stand in the way, and they never learned to stop.

Strength	Dexterity	Willpower	Charm
+2	+1	0	-1
Starting Health			
8			

Starting Gear

Longsword, 3 damage

Chainmail, Armor 1

Shield, Armor 1

Torch x2

Rations x3

d6	Perk
1	Add Strength to damage in hand-to-hand combat.
2	Once a fight, take a hit meant for someone at Close range.
3	Choose your favorite Armor and gain an extra +1 Armor while your character wears it.
4	Your character can mend a battlefield wound and restore 1 Health as an action.
5	Increase Strength, Dexterity, or Charm by 1, to a maximum of +3.
6	Increase one Stat by 1, to a maximum of +3.

Witch

Had a place in an order once, then something answered.

Strength	Dexterity	Willpower	Charm
-1	0	+2	+1
Starting Health			
5			

Starting Gear

A staff from the character's old order, holding 9 Exposure and an effect they did not create

Sleep powder

A bone-handled knife, 2 damage

Torch

Rations x3

d6	Perk
1	Increase one Stat by 1, to a maximum of +3.
2	Gain or improve a Spell Tag when the kept casting dice are double 4s or double 5s.
3	Increase Charm by 1, to a maximum of +3.
4	Your character can befriend as many ordinary cats as they wish. Roll to see if they follow your character's orders.
5	Roll with advantage when casting with a Spell Tag.
6	Your character has a murder of crows that obeys your commands.

Game Master Guide

Monsters

Four numbers and two questions.

Threat, Damage, Health, Armor, then what undoes it and what it wants. That fits on an index card.

Tiers

d6	Tier	Stats and example
1	Pest	Threat: -1; Damage: 1; Health: 3; Armor: 0; Goblin.
2	Minion	Threat: 0; Damage: 2; Health: 5; Armor: 1; Bandit or bear.
3	Glass Cannon	Threat: +1; Damage: 3; Health: 10; Armor: 0; Mummy.
4	Horror	Threat: +2; Damage: 3; Health: 15; Armor: 2; Ooze.
5	Boss	Threat: +2; Damage: 4; Health: 20; Armor: 3; Demon.
6	Mythic	Threat: +3; Damage: 5; Health: 30; Armor: 5; Dragon.

Choose the tier level that fits, or roll 1d6 and let the dice decide. Rolling works well when you are improvising or want the danger to surprise you too.

Running one

- Roll 2d6 plus Threat when a monster attacks. See Core Rules.
- Damage applies to all its attacks. A bear might bite or swipe, but both deal 2 damage.
- Weakness is what gives the characters an edge. Plant a way to discover it: a corpse, a book, a survivor, or someone who faced the creature before.
- Desire is what the monster wants besides killing the characters. Anything with a Desire can potentially be bargained with.
- For a monster caster, roll twice on Spell Tag Sparks and combine the results into a casting theme.
- A group of monsters attacking one character at the same time rolls once, using its highest Threat and best single Damage. Its numbers can still surround characters, block exits, or create other complications.
- A monster with Threat +2 or higher can attack twice on its turn. An individual monster may break this rule when it fits.

Worked monsters are in the Bestiary.

Morale

When a monster falls to half Health or less, roll 2d6 plus Threat.

Total	Result
6 or less	It flees, surrenders, or bargains.
7 to 9	It changes tactics or pursues its Desire.
10 or greater	It holds.

The GM may call for another morale roll after the monster takes more damage. Mindless, driven, or bound creatures do not roll Morale.

Mythic monsters

Health alone never kills a Mythic. Its Weakness is the only thing that can end it.

When a Mythic reaches zero Health without its Weakness being exploited, it withdraws or changes. If it changes, restore its Health and make it worse.

Telegraph this from the beginning. Wounds close. Severed limbs reform. The blade comes away clean. Killing the figure beneath the robe only kills the robe.

Bestiary

Use the rules and tiers in Monsters.

Tier 1, Goblin, Pest

Threat	Damage	Health	Armor
-1	1	3	0

- **Attacks:** Rusty knife, rocks, biting.
- **Weakness:** Bright light drives them back.
- **Desire:** Something shiny, and to see tomorrow.

Tier 2, Bear, Minion

Threat	Damage	Health	Armor
0	2	5	1

- **Attacks:** Bite, swipe, bull rush.
- **Weakness:** Fire, which no animal will face.
- **Desire:** To be left alone.

Tier 3, Mummy, Glass Cannon

Threat	Damage	Health	Armor
+1	3	10	0

- **Attacks:** Grasping hands, choking wrappings.
- **Weakness:** Fire.
- **Desire:** To punish whoever opened the door.

Tier 4, Ooze, Horror

Threat	Damage	Health	Armor
+2	3	15	2

- **Attacks:** Engulf, acid touch, drops from above.
- **Weakness:** Salt, or high ground.
- **Desire:** To dissolve and absorb metals.

Tier 5, The Frayed Man, Boss

Too many joints, a second mouth, something moving under the coat.

Threat	Damage	Health	Armor
+2	4	20	3

- **Attacks:** Grasping limbs, a crushing grip.
- **Casts:** Up to 8 Exposure. Bind, Drain, Mutate.
- **Weakness:** Hot gossip. He just cannot get enough.
- **Desire:** To kill Steve.

Tier 6, The Last Dragon, Mythic

Ancient, scarred, too large for the ruins it calls home, and remembers every wound.

Threat	Damage	Health	Armor
+3	5	30	5

- **Attacks:** Crushing jaws, sweeping tail, furnace breath.
- **Weakness:** It must be killed with something that has never been used as a weapon.
- **Desire:** To destroy every surviving account of dragons so no one remembers how to kill one.

Reference Tables

Mutation Table

d66	Mutation
11	Eyes: Roll 1d6: (1) glow, (2) reflective black, (3) faded gray, (4) blood red, (5) wood, (6) purple
12	Sharp teeth
13	Long pointed elf ears
14	One body part doubles in size. Roll 1d6: (1) fingers, (2) forearms, (3) neck, (4) calves, (5) hands, (6) hips
15	Claws
16	Forked tongue
21	Your limbs become removable and reattachable.
22	Covered in: Roll 1d6: (1) fur, (2) feathers, (3) warts, (4) tiny blinking eyes, (5) moving symbols, (6) grass
23	A large shell grows on your back
24	Skin changes: Roll 1d6: (1) bark, (2) metal, (3) scales, (4) rock, (5) barnacles, (6) see-through skin
25	Grow a large tail
26	Turn into a talking version of your childhood pet
31	1d6 more eyes
32	Gills, can breathe underwater
33	Antlers
34	Grow long, pointed horns from your head
35	Your skull becomes soft and your brain doubles in size, pulsing with light. You can read people's emotions.
36	Grow wings
41	Your flesh becomes soft wax that can be reshaped.
42	Hear and smell 10x better. Loud sounds or strong smells bother you.
43	Become a talking house cat
44	Burning touch
45	Grow 1d8 long tentacles from your back
46	Bird legs
51	A second mouth
52	A second face, on the back of your head
53	Reptilian, cold and slit-eyed
54	Limbs become moving roots
55	Your size changes. Roll 1d6: (1) mouse, (2) cat, (3) young child, (4) horse, (5) one-story house, (6) four-story building
56	A single red eye grows from your forehead while your other eyes shrink to nothing
61	Float 4 feet above the ground
62	Become a moving piece of ice and freeze everything you touch
63	Become faceless
64	Your form changes. Roll 1d6: (1) gas, (2) ooze, (3) water, (4) rock, (5) fire, (6) energy
65	Your hands become giant crab claws
66	Come apart into a swarm of bugs with a hive mind.

Wild Magic

d66	Wild Magic
11	Wild lights fill the sky.
12	Every small object nearby turns faintly sticky.
13	Everyone nearby grows three feet of hair.
14	Every nearby animal can speak for the rest of the scene.
15	The character's shadow detaches and acts on its own.
16	Every nearby liquid turns to jelly.
21	Everyone nearby swaps voices with the person to their left.
22	People nearby grow antlers.
23	Rain falls upward for 1d6 minutes.
24	The character's voice comes from the nearest closed container for the next day.
25	A nearby object becomes intelligent, talkative, and deeply opinionated.
26	Every nearby flame floats like a balloon until extinguished.
31	Nearby people become dogs for the rest of the scene.
32	The area has moon gravity for the rest of the scene.
33	Down becomes the direction the character faces for the rest of the scene.
34	Everyone nearby shrinks to mouse size for 1d6 hours.
35	Every nearby reflection steps out and walks away.
36	Every nearby door opens to the same unfamiliar room for the rest of the scene.
41	Nearby writing rearranges to reveal a secret about whoever reads it.
42	Everyone nearby becomes transparent except for their bones for the next day.
43	Nearby metal softens like clay for 1d6 hours.
44	Weather from another season fills the area for 1d6 hours.
45	The nearest dead creature wakes for one minute and demands an answer to its question.
46	The last ten seconds repeat 1d6 times. Everyone remembers each loop.
51	Every nonliving thing nearby turns to sand.
52	Total darkness fills the area for 1d6 months.
53	A tear opens in the air. Something beyond sees and remembers the character.
54	Everyone nearby ages 2d10 years.
55	Plants erupt from every crack, splitting roads, walls, and foundations as they consume the area.
56	A pillar of raw Aether erupts from the character, hurting and exposing everyone nearby. Survivors may become Arcanists.
61	The surrounding area becomes dead land. Plants die, water spoils, and nothing grows there.
62	A portal to a void dimension tears open and stays open. Something beyond notices.
63	Gravity reverses across the area permanently. Anything unanchored falls into the sky.
64	Every living thing in the area Mutates once, including the character.
65	The entire area is torn from the world and dropped somewhere impossible.
66	A hole opens in reality and spreads. Its edge erases anything it touches. It will not close on its own.

Spell Tag Sparks

When a player needs a Spell Tag idea, roll once or choose one. To create a monster caster, roll twice and combine the results into a casting theme. **Fire + Memory** might burn away memories. **Bone + Space** might call distant skeletons.

d66	Spark
11	Fire
12	Ice
13	Lightning
14	Wind
15	Water
16	Stone
21	Light
22	Darkness
23	Sound
24	Gravity
25	Time
26	Magnetism
31	Blood
32	Slime
33	Flesh
34	Plants
35	Animals
36	Swarms
41	Explosion
42	Memory
43	Undead
44	Illusion
45	Acid
46	Speed
51	Flying
52	Binding
53	Transformation
54	Invisibility
55	Destruction
56	Healing
61	Portal
62	Mind reading
63	Duplication
64	Disease
65	Decay
66	Weather

Key Ideas

■ Making money

Arcanists can make and sell relics. For some, it is a living. Wizarding schools may keep their Arcanist suppliers on the down-low. Common folk do not need to know that their magic items come from people slowly turning into monsters.

■ Magic is a team sport

Magic can be a team effort. Separate casts can build on each other.

One character creates fire, another opens a portal, and a third blows the fire through it. Price and roll each cast separately. Each character gains Exposure for their own cast.

■ Arcanists might be scary

Anyone who can rewrite reality is dangerous. Common folk may fear Arcanists. Powerful people may hunt, recruit, hide, or control them before they grow into demigods.

Key Terms

- **Aether:** The particles and patterns that make up reality.
- **Arcanist:** A person who can perceive and command those patterns.
- **Exposure:** Raw Aether accumulated through casting.
- **Mutation:** A permanent change caused by Exposure.
- **Spell Tag:** Something the character's magic has learned to do reliably.
- **Health:** How much damage a character or monster can take before suffering worse consequences.
- **Relic:** An object that stores Exposure and performs one kind of magic.
- **Frayed:** A common term for an Arcanist visibly changed by Exposure.
- **Demon:** An Arcanist whose final inventory slot was claimed by a Mutation.

The Arcane Aether

Armor

Broken

Health

Max

Current

Character Details

Name

Age

Life Type

Archetype

Description

Other Details / Notes

Key Goals

Traits & Perks

STR

DEX

WILL

CHARM

COIN

Luck

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

6

7

8

9

10

Inventory

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

11

12

Mutations, Scars, and Fatigue

Spell Tags

Aether Exposure

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10